



## ROME ITALY

## Jewish Artichokes in Rome

With such a richness of classical sights to savor, it is too easy to miss out on Rome's other fascinating histories. Peoples from all corners of the empire made their home here, and the city's Jewish population traces its presence back two millennia. Their chefs can take credit for one of Rome's culinary highlights – *carciofi alla giudia*, delicious fried artichokes.



Against the backdrop of its imperial Roman past and the Italian Renaissance, the Italian capital is very much alive and moving with the times, ever more international in flavor. It has a vibrant

Film Festival, a modern auditorium by Renzo Piano, and MAXXI, a spectacular new contemporary art museum designed by Zaha Hadid.

However, the Eternal City's bottom line has changed not one iota. The stereotypes still run true, with scooters zooming along impossibly busy streets, flocks of robed nuns and priests everywhere, noisy neighborhood markets, and the *dolce vita* very much in evidence. The city's host of neighborhood trattorias could have been plucked straight from Italian films of the 1960s, when a *mezza porzione* (half a helping, and therefore cheaper) was commonplace. Down-to-earth and run by no-nonsense waiters, these trattorias serve exclusively traditional fare, rich, delicious, and tomatoey, like *coda alla vaccinara* (braised oxtail) and *spaghetti all'amatriciana*, with tomato, onion, chili pepper, and tangy cured bacon.

One item offered nonstop from October through to June is the typical plump, round Roman (or globe) artichoke. These are usually cooked in one of two

ways, each radically different but both avoiding the tiresome ritual of scraping the flesh off the leaves. *Carciofi alla romana* entails slow-braising artichokes in garlic and parsley with a dash of broth. Soft as butter, they are a divine eating experience, as the whole artichoke can be simply sliced and eaten. A different and unusual technique is used for *carciofi alla giudia* ("in the Jewish way"); the artichokes are squashed "face down" to flatten and tenderize them, then fried in olive oil. The magic happens as the outer leaves turn deliciously crisp and golden. These crunchy delights are best eaten sizzling straight out of the pan.

The handsome artichoke is related to the wild thistle and hails from the Middle East. It made its appearance in Italy as an edible vegetable in the 1500s, but its origins can be traced farther back to another classical civilization – ancient Greece. Myths hold that mighty Zeus was infatuated with the exquisite nymph Cynara, but her capricious behavior made him insane with jealousy, so he turned her into a tough, spiky green plant. However, he did give her a sweet heart, and the "heart" of the artichoke, marinated in oil and herbs and served as antipasto or on pizza, is in fact probably better known throughout the world than the leaves lovingly embraced by the recipes of Rome.



**Above** Rome's Jewish Ghetto on the banks of the Tiber is now one of the city's most eclectic neighborhoods

**Right** The imposing dome of St. Peter's Basilica covers a huge and impressive interior – the space can hold 60,000 worshippers

**Below** *Carciofi alla giudia*, Jewish-style fried artichokes, are a specialty of the ancient Ghetto district of Rome



### A Day in Rome

Central Rome, which holds the city's classic sights, is surprisingly compact and walkable, but you need to plan your time carefully to make the best of your day.

**MORNING** Go to the **Colosseum** and explore the stone tiers where spectators witnessed the ghastly blood sports of ancient Rome. Alongside is the **Forum**, with temples and public buildings, headquarters of the far-reaching Roman empire. Then walk through to **Campo de' Fiori** for its lively morning market and cafés.

**AFTERNOON** Head over to the forbidding **Castel Sant'Angelo** on the banks of the Tiber River. Designed for Emperor Hadrian as his mausoleum, over time it became a prison and even Papal apartments. Follow the broad **Via della Conciliazione** to the vast paved square in front of **St. Peter's Basilica**; the **Vatican museums** and the **Sistine Chapel** make a superb conclusion.

**EVENING** Pick a spot on **Piazza Navona**, resplendent with its gushing Baroque fountains by Bernini, for a magical alfresco dinner.

### Essentials

#### GETTING THERE

Rome has two **airports**: Fiumicino has an express **train** to Termini central train station; while smaller Ciampino has a direct **bus**.

#### WHERE TO STAY

**Hotel Panda** (inexpensive) is a family-run hotel near the Spanish Steps. [www.hotelpanda.it](http://www.hotelpanda.it)

**Daphne Trevi** (moderate) has two locations downtown. [www.daphne-rome.com](http://www.daphne-rome.com)

**Buonanotte Garibaldi** (expensive) is a hidden oasis within the Trastevere district. [www.buonanotteggaribaldi.com](http://www.buonanotteggaribaldi.com)

#### TOURIST INFORMATION

Via Parigi 11; +39 06 488 991

### Artichokes Around Italy

The artichoke is highly prized in regional cuisines around Italy. Varieties of the vegetable are used in Cynar liqueur and even in tantalizing ice cream. Sardinia boasts the yellowish *spinoso sardo*, eaten raw with oil in springtime when fresh and tender. This is also peak time for prized tiny purple *castraure*, a variety jealously cultivated on Sant'Erasmo island in the Venice lagoon. These artichokes have a distinctive bitter tang due to the salt content of the soil. At the end of the artichoke season when the head becomes bristly, market stands across northeast Italy pare off the top and sell thick *fondi* disks, kept in water and lemon juice to prevent them from turning brown.